WHILE THE PADSHAH HUNTED

When the imperial caravan led by Munim Khan left Kabul for the plains of Hindustan, the circumstances of many of the women in it had sadly altered. Hamida Banu and Bega Begum were now widowed. Hamida Banu had left her native Sind as a feisty fourteen-year-old bride and now she was returning as queen mother of the empire, at the age of thirty-one. Gulbadan had lost all her beloved brothers, dead or exiled. Only Mah-chuchak Begum, along with her children, was to remain in Kabul. The caravan included many other single women—widows, unmarried women, divorcees—Timurid women who had answered Babur's long-ago call to come to Hindustan. At Akbar's court, these Timurid women with their nostalgia for a lost world, their Turki language and their abiding memory of Timurid culture and etiquette would help the Padshah retain his link to the old ways of his ancestors.

In addition to these women were the families of all the soldiers in Hindustan and this large group made its winding way through the high mountain passes of Kabul into the fertile plains of Hindustan. The soldiers and nobility were all dressed in styles that were resolutely 'foreign': long coats and cloaks and caps all made from thick cloths and furs. At an earlier time, Babur had been notoriously disdainful of the 'peasants and people of low standing' in Hindustan who, according to his critical eye, 'go about naked. They tie on a thing called languta, a decency-clout which hangs two spans below the navel.' Babur would have been even more unimpressed had he known that kings, too, at non-Muslim courts before the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries did not wear upper garments except for a loosely draped unstitched cloth thrown around the shoulders. According to historian Balkrishan Shivram, before the influence of Islam, the 'body was viewed as an integral aspect of the person' and the untailored cloth served to emphasize the bare body. Islam, however, held that God provided clothing to cover man's essentially shameful nakedness. Not only was the body to be covered but clothing was to be modest and loose-fitting, reflected in a medieval Persian saying: 'neither men nor women should wear a tight robe beneath which their body is revealed'. This sartorial restriction, however,